



3 Productive skills: the formal email or letter

Productive skills · IB Diploma · Concept guide and original exam-style practice

Understand the concept

The formal email or letter is a text type used for requests, complaints, applications or formal information exchange. It requires a consistent formal register with no contractions or slang, a salutation and sign-off appropriate to whether the recipient's name is known, and a structure of reason for writing, developed body content, and a polite closing action or request. Register and layout conventions are assessed alongside content and language range.

Worked example: follow the reasoning

Dear Ms Alvarez,
I am writing to enquire about the volunteer positions advertised on your school's website last week. I have attached my availability for the coming term and would be grateful for further details about the application process.
Yours sincerely,
J. Torres

Quick check · multiple choice

Which closing phrase is appropriate for a formal letter addressed to 'Dear Sir or Madam'?

- A Yours sincerely
- B Yours faithfully
- C See you soon
- D Cheers

Write your choice: _____

Structured practice

Answer in the space provided.

- 1 Write a formal email of 250-400 words to the director of a local library, requesting permission to organize a weekly language-exchange evening for teenagers on the library premises. Explain the purpose of the event, propose a schedule, and ask what conditions the library would require. [25]

Final answer: _____



Answers and explanation

Question 1 [25]

A high-scoring response includes:

- Formal salutation ('Dear Mr/Ms [Surname]' or 'Dear Sir or Madam') and matching sign-off
- A clear opening stating the reason for writing in the first lines
- A developed body: purpose of the event, target participants, proposed day/time, expected numbers, and any resources needed such as a room or wifi
- A specific, polite closing request, such as asking for a meeting or confirmation, rather than a vague ending
- Consistently formal register throughout: no contractions, no slang, full sentences, formal connectors such as furthermore or therefore
- Word count within 250-400 words, organized in clear paragraphs

Quick check answer

B. 'Yours faithfully' is used when the recipient's name is unknown; 'Yours sincerely' is used when it is known.

Self-assessment

Compare each credited step with your own answer. Fix the first reasoning or content error, then retry the practice question without looking at the solution.

Based on the IB English B guide (2018).

Original FagusED teaching material. Not an official IB publication; the sample scenarios and language are invented and generic.